



BK RAMESH

BANGALORE | Repeat Value

H.D. Deve Gowda is not one to believe that prime minister-ship is a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity. The 76-year-old former prime minister, the rank outsider who made it to the top job, thinks he is destined to scale those heights again. The announcement of the five-phase polls for the Lok Sabha almost coincided with Gowda cobbling up a Third Front consisting of eight parties, including the Left, which will be formally launched on March 12 in Karnataka. "We want to remain equi-distant from the Congress and BJP," says the JD(S) supremo. The Third Front will comprise the JD(S), CPI(M), CPI, Forward Bloc, Revolutionary Socialist Party, Telugu Desam Party, the Telangana Rashtra Samithi and the AIADMK besides leaders like Prakash Karat, A.B. Bardhan, Chandrababu Naidu, Chandrasekar Rao and Jayalalithaa. With most pundits predicting that the big parties can't deliver in the elections, much will depend on what happens at the negotiating table in post-poll bargaining. Gowda may shake hands with the Congress if the numbers add up. "We know who the common enemy is," says the dark horse who became India's 14th prime minister and whose favourite one-liner is that history has a habit of repeating itself. *by Stephen David*

GOWDA SEEMS TO BE WAITING FOR PERSONAL HISTORY TO REPEAT ITSELF

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parties have come together to form the Third Front led by Gowda, who hopes to give bigger parties a run for votes in the coming elections.